BUSINESS INSIDER

From Publisher to Platform:

Three Moves to Convert 18-34 Year-Olds Into Subscribers

112

Survey responses

70

Aged 18-34

4

Research pillars

3

Strategic moves

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Consulting Team: Hannuo | Amaan | Izzie | Icy | Praswanth

Three Workstreams Address the Problem in Sequence, and Each One Sets Up the Next

01 Reporter-as-Creator and Social Funnel

Reporter-as-Creator and Social Funnel

Fix the handoff from social discovery to BI's owned ecosystem. Named reporter-led short-form video formats paired with a referral mechanic that removes paywall friction entirely on first touch.

02 Free Daily Briefing and Newsletter Verticals

Free Daily Briefing and Newsletter Verticals

Build a daily reading ritual before asking for money. A free personalized briefing builds the habit. Two career-utility newsletter verticals, Money Memo and Career Dispatch, are the subscription offer that follows.

03 AI as Production Force-Multiplier

AI as Production Force-Multiplier

Scale output without diluting editorial trust. A phased 90-day AI pilot expands BI's production capacity. Human reporters retain editorial voice and judgment at every stage.

We Surveyed 112 People and Researched Four Pillars, Wide in Reach, Deep in Learning

SECONDARY RESEARCH | Four Pillars

01 **Vertical Video Mechanics**
Reporter-led format testing, 3-second hook analysis and mobile-first retention metrics

02 **Market Gap Analysis**
Competitive audits of NYT, WSJ, Bloomberg and Substack to find underserved verticals

03 **Growth and Monetization**
Referral mechanics, paywall friction mapping and employer-bundle pricing strategy

04 **AI Strategy and Trust**
How AI affects reader trust, paywall bypass behavior and content production capacity

PRIMARY SURVEY | What We Found

112
Total survey respondents

70
Aged 18-34 (target segment)

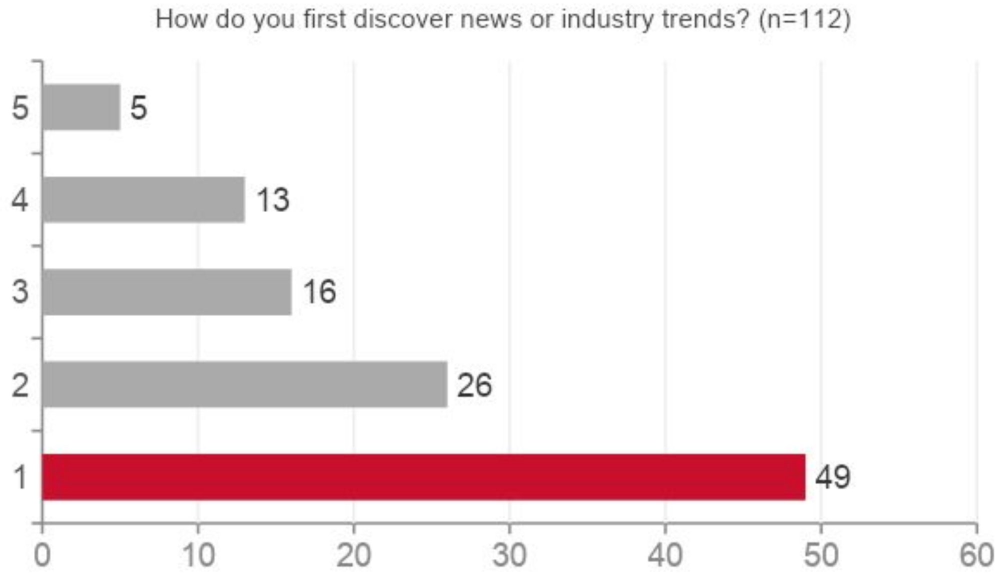
30
Questions across all 4 pillars

63%
Majority in core demographic

Bottom line: We went wide across 112 respondents to find patterns, and deep into four research pillars to understand the competitive context. Every recommendation that follows draws from both.

Social Media Is BI's Primary Discovery Channel, But Readers Arrive Through Platforms BI Cannot Monetize

PRIMARY SURVEY n=112



BI's reach is borrowed, not owned

49 of 112 respondents discover news first on social. BI's content is found on TikTok, Instagram and YouTube, platforms that capture engagement value without returning it to BI.

Email is an underused loyalty asset

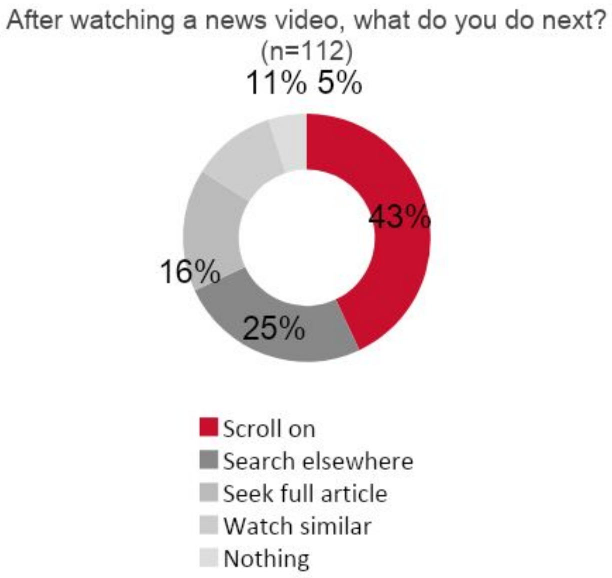
Only 13 respondents cite newsletters as their primary discovery channel, despite newsletters delivering the highest subscription conversion rates in digital media.

The morning window is the key activation moment

Early morning before 9am is the number one consumption time slot. BI's notification and newsletter cadence should target 6-8am to compete for this daily habit window.

43% Scroll Past After a News Video; BI Captures Only 16% Who Seek the Full Article

PRIMARY SURVEY n=112



43%

scroll past without engaging further

16%

seek the full article on BI

How to close the gap

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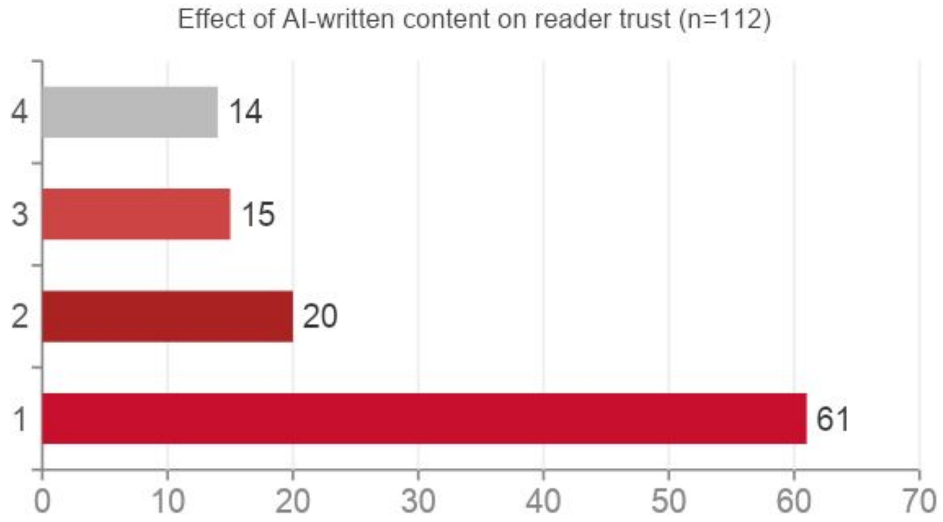
A reporter visible in the first 3 seconds drives significantly higher retention than a title card or voiceover alone

Embedding an article link as an on-screen call to action captures the 16% already looking for more

A referral mechanic replaces paywall friction with peer trust at the moment of conversion

84% Say AI-Written Content Erodes Trust, Yet 63% Already Use AI to Bypass BI's Paywall

PRIMARY SURVEY n=112



63%

use AI to bypass paywalls occasionally

55%

still read with visible human sign-off

What this means for BI

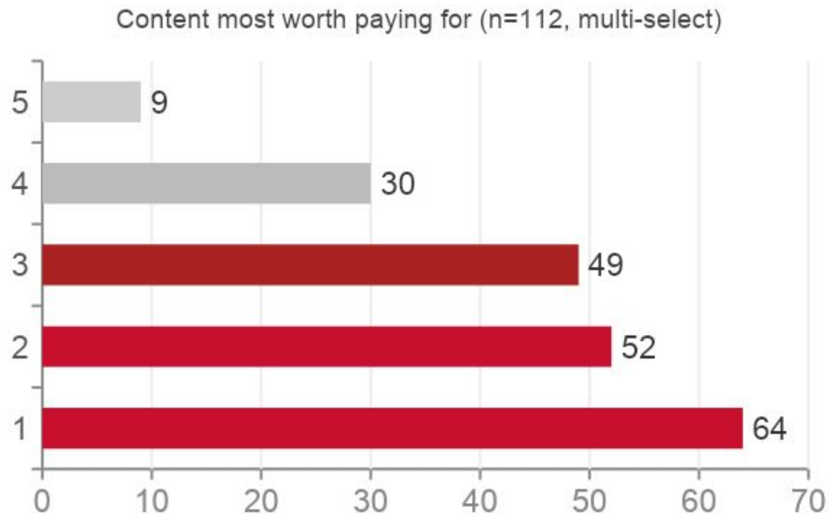
AI is most dangerous as a substitute for human journalism. BI's competitive advantage is its named reporters, editorial point of view and institutional credibility. None of these can be replicated by a language model.

However, 55% would still read AI-assisted content when human sign-off is clearly visible. AI as a production tool is viable. AI as an author is not.

RISK: Readers who habitually use AI to summarize BI articles have a significantly lower subscription conversion probability. Reducing paywall friction is a parallel priority, not a sequential one.

Career Utility Unlocks Willingness to Pay; BI Underserves the Three Verticals This Audience Values Most

PRIMARY SURVEY n=112



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Personal Finance

HIGH

Morning Brew leads here; BI wins on data journalism depth and source access

Career Development

HIGH

LinkedIn dominates on reach; BI beats them on reporting depth and insider access

Entrepreneurship

GROWING

Substack and podcast creators own this; BI has no dedicated newsletter presence

38% of respondents would pay $10+ per month if content supports career or investment decisions | 39% have employer subscription budgets, B2B path is validated

The Discovery Is Happening. The Conversion Is Not. Friction at the Social-to-Owned Handoff Is the Root Problem.

49 of 112

PRIMARY SURVEY

respondents discover BI first on social media. The audience exists. The designed path from social into BI's owned ecosystem does not.

51%

SECONDARY RESEARCH

of 18-34 year-olds pay more attention to individual news creators than to news brand accounts. The reporter personality is the hook, not the BI masthead.

85%+

SECONDARY RESEARCH

referral conversion rate achieved by Morning Brew using a peer-invite mechanic. Peer trust removes the paywall moment entirely for new subscribers.

IMPLICATION: Build a 4-step funnel: Hook via reporter-led video, Bridge to BI article with no paywall on first touch. Engage through daily briefing and newsletter opt-in, Convert through referral mechanic and employer bundle.

Readers Do Not Cancel Because of Price. They Cancel Because BI Never Became Part of Their Daily Routine.

Not a content problem.
A ritual problem.

35%

of respondents who cancelled said they did not use it enough, not that it was too expensive or too low quality. Habit is the retention mechanism.

73/112

respondents said daily one-minute summaries would bring them back every day, the top habit driver, nearly double personalized feeds and newsletters.

90 days

is the make-or-break retention window. Habit and community features extend subscriber lifetime by 13-24%. The subscription ask must come after the habit forms.

The 5-Visit Rule

Surface the subscription offer only after a reader has returned 5 or more times. Measure return visits over 30 to 60 days. Convert the habitual reader, not just the curious one.

IMPLICATION: BI does not have a content problem. It has a ritual problem. A free personalized daily briefing with no paywall is the habit engine. Career and finance newsletter verticals are the subscription product that follows.

INSIGHT 03 | AI STRATEGY

AI Destroys Value as an Author and Creates Value as Invisible Production Infrastructure.

AI AS AUTHOR | destroys trust	AI AS PRODUCTION TOOL | scales output, preserves trust
AI-written bylines: 84% of survey respondents say this reduces trust or willingness to pay	Video transcription and script generation from existing reporter interviews
AI making news judgment calls or setting the editorial agenda	Article-to-newsletter brief conversion, cutting production time without replacing editorial voice
AI-generated video presenters with no human face or voice	SEO optimisation, headline A/B testing and topic trend detection
	Personalized content feed curation to increase return visit frequency and reduce churn

PRIMARY SURVEY n=112

55% of respondents would still read AI-assisted content when human sign-off is clearly visible. The guardrail is transparency and human oversight, not the absence of AI entirely.

Three Reporter-Led Video Formats and a Referral Funnel Convert Social Viewers Into Subscribers Without a Hard Paywall

DISCOVER

TikTok / Instagram / YouTube

Reporter-led 60-second hook

>

BRIDGE

BI Article or Newsletter

Frictionless link, no paywall on first touch

>

ENGAGE

Daily Briefing and Newsletter

Career Intel and Money Moves opt-in

>

CONVERT

Referral Mechanic and Employer Bundle

Peer trust removes paywall friction

The Brief

Daily | 60 seconds

Named BI reporter covers the top 3 business headlines. Opens with reporter on screen. Closes with a direct link to the full article on BI.

Money Moves

3x per week | 90 seconds

Personal finance reporter covers one actionable topic per episode. Connects to the Money Memo newsletter with a direct opt-in call to action.

Career Intel

2x per week | 2 minutes

Job market reporter with an occasional guest expert. Connects to Career Dispatch newsletter. Subscriber opt-in embedded in the final frame.

A Free Daily Briefing Builds the Reading Ritual; Two Career-Utility Newsletters Are the Subscription Offer

FREE DAILY BRIEFING | No paywall | No subscription required

60-second personalized briefing by interest area. No paywall. Surface the subscription offer only after 5 or more return visits.

MONEY MEMO

PERSONAL FINANCE | EVERY MONDAY

- Salary negotiation playbooks
- Investing basics: ETFs and index funds
- Side income and freelance tax strategy
- Financial planning for career transitions

Gap: Morning Brew leads here; BI wins on data journalism depth and source access

CAREER DISPATCH

CAREER DEVELOPMENT | EVERY WEDNESDAY

- Job market weekly pulse
- Skills in demand: AI, data and finance
- Interview preparation with industry insiders
- Workplace culture and remote work trends

Gap: LinkedIn dominates on reach; BI beats them on reporting depth and insider access

Pricing: $5 to $10 per month (48% of respondents) | Employer-billed bundles for the 39% with company subscription budgets

Deploy AI as a Production Force-Multiplier Now and Build a Proprietary Content Data Advantage Over Time

PHASE 1 | 90-Day Production Pilot

10% Pilot | Days 1-30

AI-assisted video transcription, article-to-script conversion and thumbnail A/B testing. Human editors review all output before every publish.

25% Scale | Days 31-60

Newsletter brief generation, SEO headline optimisation and topic trend detection. Measure quality and engagement versus manual baseline.

50% Integration | Days 61-90

Full workflow integration with human-in-the-loop sign-off at every stage. AI handles production scale; reporters retain editorial voice and judgment.

PHASE 2 | Content Data Advantage

01 Insider Knowledge Base

Structure 10+ years of verified BI reporting into a searchable intelligence product. Validated by 70% of respondents expressing interest in a single company-intelligence platform.

02 Proprietary Data Layer

BI's exclusive source relationships, verified documents and investigative datasets cannot be replicated by a public language model. This is the defensible content moat.

03 Content Licensing Recovery

Identify unauthorized use of BI content and convert those contacts into licensing relationships, recovering revenue from a high-margin stream.

Our Recommendations Carry Real AI Risks, These Five Guardrails Make Them Work

1

No AI bylines

Reporters own every piece of content. AI is invisible production infrastructure, never a named contributor or author.

2

Human editorial sign-off before every publish

Every AI-assisted piece requires reporter or editor approval before going live. No exceptions at any stage of the pilot.

3

AI never sets the editorial agenda

AI surfaces trend signals and suggests topics based on engagement data. Reporters make every news judgment call.

4

Trust metrics monitored weekly

Shares, time on page and subscription rates tracked continuously. Any decline triggers immediate review of AI output.

5

Proprietary data isolated from external crawlers

BI's investigative data, source notes and exclusive datasets are separated from public AI training pipelines and external API access.

DATA VALIDATION | 55% of respondents would still read AI-assisted content when human sign-off is clearly visible. Transparency is the guardrail, not the absence of AI.

Three Work Streams Over 90 Days Build the Habit First and Unlock Subscription Conversion by Month 6.

WORKSTREAM 1

Reporter-as-Creator and Social Funnel

Week 1 Define 3 video formats and production template

Week 4 Pilot The Brief: 5 episodes, measure retention

Week 8 Launch Money Moves and Career Intel formats

Week 12 Publish video playbook and make scale decision

WORKSTREAM 2

Daily Briefing and Newsletter Verticals

Week 1 Audit newsletter list and define vertical segments

Week 4 Launch Money Memo pilot to 5,000 subscribers

Week 8 Launch Career Dispatch and A/B test subject lines

Week 12 Analyze open rates, clicks and paid conversion

WORKSTREAM 3

AI Production Pilot

Week 1 Identify AI tools and define governance rules

Week 4 10% pilot: transcription and script generation

Week 8 25% expansion: newsletter briefs and SEO

Week 12 Review metrics and make 50% integration decision

Success metrics: 35%+ video retention | 500+ newsletter opt-ins per week | Paywall conversion lift of 15% by Month 6